

WEEK 10 · WORK

CLASS 1

Help, Choice, Obligation, Labor?

READING 1

“Chapter 1: ‘If I Don’t Help Them, Who Will?’” and “Chapter 4: Making a Living Together” in *Kids at Work* – Estrada

Kids at Work: Latinx Families Selling Food on the Streets of Los Angeles | Estrada

Week 10, Class 1

Chapter 1: "If I Don't Help Them, Who Will?" — pp. 23–42

Chapter 4: "Making a Living Together" — pp. 83–98

Estrada, Emir. 2019. "If I Don't Help Them, Who Will?" (chap. 1) and "Making a Living Together" (chap. 4). In *Kids at Work: Latinx Families Selling Food on the Streets of Los Angeles*, 23–42 and 83–98. *Latina/o Sociology Series*. New York: New York University Press.

1

“If I Don’t Help Them, Who Will?”

The Working Life

At the age of fourteen, Joaquín identified an opportunity to earn extra money at his school to help his family. Joaquín’s mom was a sewing operator at a clothing factory in Pico Rivera and his father worked as a handyman. They provided for him and his two younger siblings, but as the oldest son, he wanted to help. Although he knew that school policy prohibited him from selling his wares at school, he did it anyway. With his extra backpack full of merchandise, Joaquín would spend recess with his customers, some of whom were also teachers. Joaquín remembered one day when a security guard at his school signaled for him to come over as he was dropping off books at his locker and picking up his “second” backpack. Joaquín’s friends looked at him with concern, but Joaquín walked over with confidence as he clutched his second backpack. At the end of the long hallway of metal lockers and blue-and-white checkered tile floor, the tall, muscular security guard waited for him with two dollars in hand. Joaquín took the money and, in exchange, gave him two small bags of chips and routinely asked whether he wanted Tapatio hot sauce.

Eighteen-year-old Joaquín laughed when he told me this suspenseful story in the living room of his house to explain his first experience vending food. His mother, Rosa, quietly shook her head and tried to control her laughter while she washed dishes in the kitchen. When Joaquín decided to sell chips, his parents were not street vendors, but one day he simply came up with the idea and told his mom, “Quisiera vender papas en la escuela” (I would like to sell chips at school)—and so he did. Joaquín opted to sell chips at school after seeing the demand for these types of snacks. He recalled, “A lot of people jumped the iron fence to go to the liquor stores” to buy chips because it was

24 | “IF I DON’T HELP THEM, WHO WILL?”



Figure 1.1. Boy making juice.

against school policy to sell chips and sodas inside the school premises. With enthusiasm Joaquín elaborated:

It got to the point where I had to take two backpacks full of chips because I was making money in high school. They already knew me. Every time I was at school, I was either doing my work or selling during my free time. They would come and they would ask me, “Do you have chips?” Teachers would ask me, too. The security guards used to buy my stuff. We had security in the halls to make sure we didn’t do graffiti. They would always see me with my bag and they would buy chips too.

Little did Joaquín know that just one year later, circumstances would push him and his family to seek street vending as a financial alternative

“IF I DON’T HELP THEM, WHO WILL?” | 25

when his mother was fired from her job of fifteen years. Rosa had become ill over the years, and finally her employer decided to let her go, citing her undocumented status as a reason. She was fired with neither medical coverage nor severance pay. After Rosa lost her job, her husband became the only breadwinner. Again, Joaquín realized that his family was in need of help, and he chose to street vend with his uncles. Joaquín explained, “I went with my uncles one Saturday and I started vending. I helped them and noticed I made money. I said, I want to do this, and the first thing my uncle asked was if I was embarrassed.” Later, Rosa joined her son and together they sold fresh orange, carrot, and beet juice on Saturdays and Sundays at a busy business district in Los Angeles.

Joaquín continued going to high school while street vending and graduated on time. When I met him, he was a freshman at a state university in California, where he was double majoring in sociology and criminology. Sadly, Rosa did not see her son graduate from college. Two years after Rosa and her son started street vending, she was diagnosed with cancer and passed away while I was still conducting my study.



Figure 1.2. Girl making juice.

Joaquín’s story exemplifies the structural realities that motivate children to enact their agency in order to find economic solutions to help their parents. While it is well-documented why first-generation immigrants enter street vending, we know less about how and why children like Joaquín get involved in the family street vending business and what role they play in it.¹

Street vending and family-pooled income strategies requiring that children work *are* common practices in countries like México.² A good deal of research on child labor and street vending has been conducted in “developing countries” in Africa, Asia, and Latin America.³ However, these economic strategies are not uncommon in the United States.⁴ What explains this? Some commentators might assume that the children of immigrants engage in street vending in Los Angeles as a cultural holdover from México, their parents’ country. I argue that cultural explanations alone cannot explain why children and youth work as street vendors with their immigrant parents in East Los Angeles.

Structural Forces: “If I Don’t Help Them, Who Will?”

Joaquín’s story is also not unique among the children who shared their stories with me. All of the children in this study cited their parents’ lack of legal status and lack of access to formal sector work as the reason why they needed to help make ends meet. For example, Norma, who had just turned eighteen, and her younger brother Salvador, age twelve, faced an important decision to make when their father, Pedro, lost his job soon after they immigrated from México, where they had been living with their mother. Pedro left his wife and two children in México for ten years; in 2009 he used most of his savings to pay a smuggler to bring his family to Boyle Heights, California, where he used to share an apartment with other immigrants from his hometown.

Essentially, this family experienced profound ambivalence. On the one hand, they rejoiced at being together again after a long period of separation, and on the other hand, they faced the harsh economic reality of unemployment. Salvador was only two years old when his father immigrated to the United States; his father-son interactions mostly entailed weekly phone conversations and periodic gifts on his birthday. Norma has more vivid memories of her father before he left, but she too was

“IF I DON’T HELP THEM, WHO WILL?” | 27

having a difficult time adjusting to their new family arrangement in the United States.⁵ Before he brought his family to the United States, Pedro consistently sent remittances, and both Norma and her little brother Salvador focused entirely on their schoolwork.⁶ With his family now in Los Angeles, Norma’s father had to find a way to make money fast, but he was unable to find stable employment. When Norma’s father had the idea to sell tacos de barbacoa (goat meat), he first asked his children whether they would help. Norma explained,

My father asked us if we would agree to sell tacos de barbacoa on the street and he also asked if we could help him because they were not going to be able to do this on their own, and we said yes.

This is a typical conversation between parents and children when entering this occupation for the first time. This was unknown territory for all. Parents recognized that children’s help was important, and so was their opinion. After seeing the financial needs at home, moreover, the children made a conscientious and mature decision to help.

When I interviewed Norma and her family, they had been selling tacos de barbacoa in front of a junkyard for almost a year. The truck served as an improvised store tent, and a blue tarp stretched from the truck onto a hook Salvador helped screw on the wall. Salvador and his father were in charge of setting up their stand with two large folding tables, chairs for customers, and the skillet to heat up the meat and tortillas. Norma was almost always in charge of heating up the tortillas, while her mother and sometimes her father prepared the tacos and served a traditional birria broth in a separate cup (birria is a spicy stew made from goat meat). Salvador or one of the parents typically handled the cash transactions. During my time with this family, I saw Salvador inside the truck many times taking breaks and playing with his new portable video game, but after my interview with him, I discovered that he did most of his share of the work at home, the night before they street vend. Salvador told me that he is the one in charge of cooking the goat meat in the backyard of their house. When Salvador told me how he cooked the goat meat by himself, I could see a spark of pride, though he seldom looked up when he talked. At the young age of twelve, he had already become a master chef and was excellent at

seasoning this traditional dish from their native town in Jalisco. Children like Salvador allowed me to see that there is more to street vending than the actual street work. Much of the work these kids do takes place off the streets because children are involved in many aspects of behind-the-scenes prep work. For example, while Salvador prepares and cooks the goat meat for several hours, Norma chops onions and cilantro inside their kitchen.

While children typically got involved in street vending work after their parents lost their jobs, soon they realized the importance of their work and family contribution. In many cases, refusing to help meant not being able to pay the rent, buy groceries, or even afford their own personal wants and desires such as toys, clothes, and technological gadgets.⁷ During my interview with fourteen-year-old Karen, she explained that she had convinced her mother to go back to street vending after she lost her iPod, a gadget that stored digital songs and pictures. In Karen’s case, there was no urgent need to street vend, but simply a desire to replace a very expensive toy that cost about \$200. Her mother, Olga, recounted, “Entonces ella y yo volvimos a vender porque ella ahorita quiere un iPod” (So she and I started vending again because she now wants an iPod.) Karen understood that it is not just a matter of replacing an expensive gadget; rather, she must literally work to get a new one.⁸

Other children felt that they were the only help their parents had. Flor, who is getting ready to celebrate her *quinceañera* (fifteenth birthday), works with her mother on Saturdays. They sell cosmetics and snacks for pedestrians at a busy commercial area in Los Angeles. When I asked Flor why she helped her mother, she replied, “Si no les ayudo yo, quién?” (If I don’t help them, who will?) Children knew that street vending required extra help. Flor highlighted the importance of her work with a taken-for-granted example. She told me, “Sometimes I cover the stand while my mom goes to the bathroom.” This was important help, especially when vendors worked for long stretches at a time. As a researcher standing among street vendors for hours at a time, even I was called on to help watch over a stand when someone had to run to the restroom at nearby restaurants.

Structural forces such as undocumented status and limited work for parents created opportunities for children to enter this occupation. However, children constantly highlighted their own agency in the

process. Many rationalized their participation in street vending work with individual characteristics that, according to them, made them more apt for this type of work.

Which Children Choose to Street Vend in Los Angeles

Independent of structural forces, children in my study told me that their decision to street vend was their own. As a researcher, I was constantly aware of my position and wondered whether their responses were ex post facto rationalizations, and I remained unsure whether this was something they felt compelled to tell me. This is ultimately left for the reader to judge. The degree of their agency or free will was made more compelling when I learned that out of the thirty-eight children interviewed, twenty-four had siblings living at home who did not work with the family regularly or at all. Individual characteristics such as an outgoing personality or having people skills were often cited as good traits for street vendors. The children frequently defined themselves in opposition to their nonworking siblings who were too shy to do this type of work.

Fourteen-year-old Leticia, for example, had two brothers who stayed home while she worked with her mother. Leticia has a bubbly personality and seemed to be happy all the time. Her smile and laughter were very contagious. Their customers and I had a difficult time keeping a straight face when in the company of Leticia and her mom. While they constantly made fun of politicians, regular customers, and themselves, I had to be careful and stay on the periphery; otherwise I would also be fair game for teasing. According to Leticia, both of her brothers lacked her outgoing personality and were simply too shy. She was right. A few times, I saw her brothers quickly stop by their stand only to drop off merchandise for the business, such as tortillas, cheese, or vegetables. Other times, they simply stopped by to pick up food to eat. Leticia did not mind that her brothers did not work with them. Yet she justified her brothers’ lack of help:

The thing with my brothers is that they are very shy. They are not very social like me. I’m loud and talkative. They are calm and they say that I’m crazy. I guess I get it from my mom. She is always talking and always

30 | “IF I DON’T HELP THEM, WHO WILL?”

meets new people and I’m like that too. My brothers are shy. They don’t like to meet new people. I guess they are scared. When they come [to the street vending stand] they talk to people, but they just stand looking around like, “What do I do next?” and I’m just, like, “Well, come here, carry this and carry that.”

Similarly, Kenya said her older sister Erica simply lacked people skills to street vend. Unlike her, she did not have the personality needed to sell and handle rude customers. Kenya did clarify that Erica will help her mom as a last resort and only if no one else can help her:

Erica has gone [street vending] before, too. Whenever, like, I can’t go or my older sister couldn’t go. But she is like, “I just don’t like it. I can’t stand it there.” She is like, “I can’t sell like you guys do.” She doesn’t have people skills or anything. She is very nice, but she won’t go.

Sometimes children like Erica had siblings who were willing to work and thus shielded them from street vending responsibilities, but not from household work. While Erica could sometimes get away with not street vending, she often stayed home and helped with the household chores. There was certainly a gender dynamic at play, since girls who opted not to street vend—unlike boys—could not opt out of household work (see chapter 5). It is important to underscore that the girls in these families are doing critical housework and social reproductive labor. Although most of the sociology of family and work, as well as feminist literature, assumes that this work is carried out by adult women, here it is daughters who are carrying a big load, often in addition to the street vending.⁹

When I interviewed the parents, they reiterated that only those children who wanted to help did so because it was an optional activity for children. José described his children’s willingness to help:

It’s work without being work. It’s helping the family, but in a different way because it’s optional. . . . Well, we always ask our kids if they want to come with me and if they say yes, I bring them. It’s like when we go to the park. If you say, do you want to go to the park, and they say let’s go, then we go. [Author’s translation]

José’s children were interviewed separately and both echoed his views about street vending. When I asked his fourteen-year-old daughter Chayo whether she had to street vend with her father, she thoughtfully replied, “No, I don’t have to come.” Both Chayo and her younger brother Juan did not feel obligated to help their father, but both knew that not helping also meant missing out on the family business earnings of twenty dollars each. Juan, who is about to turn ten, said, “I like helping my family and all because I want them to do me a birthday party. . . . That’s why I’m trying to earn money to do it myself.”

For some children, the decision to help was, as José stated earlier, like deciding to go to the park. Linda and Susana, two sisters who sold pupusas with their parents, agreed to help in a very nonchalant manner as well. Linda explained, “One day my mother just told us if we wanted to come and sell. We were like, ‘Sure, we don’t have anything else good to do.’” According to Susana, she and her sister used to “take turns” going with their mother when they sold pupusas door-to-door before they sold at La Cumbrita, one of the street vending sites where I conducted observations. Negotiations over who would help street vend were often done among siblings themselves. While some rationalize being better fit for the job, others exchanged household work obligations with sisters who could stay home to clean, cook, and care for younger siblings. Those who were stuck or opted for street vending work were not shielded from the stigma associated with street vending and what seemed to be “the worst part of their job.”

Cultural Stereotypes: “They Tell Me That I’m Right Here . . . Like a Mexican Person Selling in the Streets”

Street vending marked the children in this study as foreign and undocumented even though the majority of them were born in the United States and had never traveled to México, the place they had been told to go back countless times. One thing was certain—street vending served as an immigrant shadow for these children. Sociologist Jody Agius Vallejo found that an immigrant shadow is even present among established middle-class Mexican professionals.¹⁰ Similarly, sociologist Tomás R. Jiménez argues that due to a constant immigrant replenishment from Latin America, second- and third-generation children of immigrants are

32 | “IF I DON’T HELP THEM, WHO WILL?”

seen as forever foreign.¹¹ The youth in this study also experienced this “othering” while street vending. Their English language skills and even their own U.S. citizenship did not shield them from being labeled with an epithet such as “wetback,” to underline the racialized connotations of the job. Take the case of eighteen-year-old Veronica, who started selling cups of sliced fruit on the streets of Los Angeles with her mother when she was twelve. She recalled the teasing she had endured from school friends this way:

They used to tell me, “You sell in the streets? Aren’t you embarrassed? People look at you and you have to tell them to buy your stuff!” So they were making fun of me, and they tell me that I’m right here in the street, like a Mexican person selling in the streets. People tell me, “Ha! You’re a wetback!” . . . I wanted to cry because they were making fun of me, but then I got over it.

To be selling on the street is to be “like a Mexican person.” It marks one publicly as marginal, backward, subordinate, and inferior. Another girl also said that she imagined that people who saw her selling on the street probably saw her as “a Mexican,” when in fact, she identified as “Hispanic,” a U.S.-born U.S. citizen. She thought people would be surprised to learn she was born in the United States. This distinction and the street vendor youths’ contestation suggest the contours of widely circulating notions of racial hierarchy and immigrant inferiority.

The children were bewildered when random people told them to go “back to México.” These young vendors were proud of their Latinx heritage, and they did not accept derogatory cultural depictions of Mexicans and Latinx attached to them simply for the work they performed.¹² Accordingly, the children I interviewed described their peers who did not work as “lazy” and “spoiled.” When asked what her friends do, Chayo, who had just turned fourteen but spoke with the security of a much older person, assessed, “Nothing. They have their parents, but their parents work for them. Like, they get money either way. They don’t have to do anything.” Her ten-year-old brother Andrés disparagingly claimed that his friends were always “outside eating chips and they are all fat. . . . They just, like, always play around and eat junk food all the time.” And Edgar disdainfully said of his Catholic school peers, “They don’t even

work. They are lazy.” Not working was associated with slothfulness, junk food, and being fat.

Familiar and widely circulating racializations of Mexicans as lazy, illegal, and illegitimate were challenged by narratives that allowed the street vendor kids to position themselves as more authentically Mexican or Latinx than their nonworking peers. The street vendor kids said that their nonworking peers had lots of idle time. They reasoned that with all this idle time, their peers were more likely to get in trouble and turn to drugs, stealing, and gangs. Take the examples of the following three girls:

Street vending gets you tired, but you have, like, time to do it. And you’re not doing dumb stuff over there, seeing TV, sitting down, doing drugs, *tú sabes* [you know], not doing bad. . . . Like my cousin, he got into jail like three times already because he’s, like, stealing and doing drugs and he’s a gangster. I don’t want to be like him. (Nadya, age thirteen)

My neighbor just sleeps, smokes drugs, and then, like, he goes and eats and he doesn’t even help his parents. And I feel bad for his parents because one of them *no puede caminar* [cannot walk]. . . . Like, if it was me, I have to help my parents. (Veronica, age eighteen)

Es mejor que estés trabajando que te cachén robando. [It’s better to work than be caught stealing.] I mean, that’s the way I see it. I ain’t stealing. (Martha, age eighteen)

Across the board, the children rejected traditional stereotypes of this profession. They countered the stigma by taking pride in this “cultural” activity that made them better Mexicans in the United States as it helped them develop a strong work ethic and kept them away from gangs and drugs. For street vending children, meanings of culture did not remain stagnant; rather, the children transformed and readapted cultural meanings through their work experience with their parents.

The children defined themselves as hardworking compared to their friends. For example, Leticia said that none of her friends could handle the work that she did with her mother. One night, Leticia’s friends had a sleepover and witnessed all the work that Leticia and her family had

34 | “IF I DON’T HELP THEM, WHO WILL?”

to do the night before they went street vending. This was not a typical slumber party that entailed nail painting and boy talk. Leticia took her friends to downtown Los Angeles, where they bought the majority of their food in bulk. Once home, she diligently put away the food and made sure to separate the food for their street vending business in one refrigerator, and in another fridge, the food for the house. Later, Leticia began boiling water in different pots for the different types of salsas that she made. In one pot, she boiled tomatillo and dried chiles, in another she boiled red tomatoes with jalapeños, and so on. Leticia did not count the vegetables before putting them in the pot, as someone would while meticulously following a recipe. She cooked with confidence and skill, as if she were one of the kids depicted in the cooking show *MasterChef Junior*. In total, she made about eight different types of sauces to accompany the food they sold. Her friends were overwhelmed just by seeing all the work she had to do and confessed they could not handle even part of it. During our interview, Leticia shared that story with pride:

Most of my friends have stepdads and their moms are always home. They mostly help around the house. One time my friends slept over for a weekend and they said they can’t handle it and they don’t know how I do it.

The children told me that they stood out among their friends. While some school friends who knew of their street vending work naively made fun of them, others regarded their work with admiration and respect. For example, Joaquín told me that his friends at first made fun of him, but later he gained their respect once his schoolmates saw how the fruit of his labor materialized.

At the beginning a lot of them made fun of me, but they started seeing that I made money. They would ask me, “How come you have money?” I guess they thought I was doing something wrong, and I tell them I always liked to make money and I found ways to make money by making good things.

The list of things children disliked about street vending was long: waking up early, dealing with rude customers, running and hiding from the cops, getting tired, and so forth. However, as Joaquín put it in a very mature and matter-of-fact way, “I think I have lived my childhood and I

“IF I DON’T HELP THEM, WHO WILL?” | 35

Time	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday
5:00 AM							
6:00							
7:00	School	School	School	School	School		
8:00						work	
9:00						at	
10:00						down-town	
11:00							
12:00							
1:00 PM							
2:00							
3:00	after	after	after		after		
4:00	school	School	school		school		
5:00	program	Program	Program		school		
6:00							
7:00	Park to						
8:00	SV.	sell					
9:00	10 or 8	2 point					
10:00	or 8 to						
11:00							
12:00							
Income	\$	\$	\$	\$	\$	\$45.00	\$45.00
From sales							

Figure 1.3. Handwritten work schedule of Adriana (age thirteen).

think it's time to face the real world.” While children enacted their own agency, they also recognized that they had very limited options. Not helping would not only hurt their parents, but it would ultimately hurt them directly as well.

When Do Children Work?

Vacation Work

The children filled out a time schedule showing me what a typical week in their life looked like. One student jokingly said on her last day of school, “My vacation time has ended.” By this she meant that she worked more during the summer than she did during the school year. Others echoed this sentiment. When I looked at Leticia’s schedule, I was amazed by the number of hours she worked with her mom. She worked over forty-five hours per week. Immediately she clarified, “It’s ’cause I’m on vacation. I have more time now.” These young street vendors were ubiquitous on the streets of Los Angeles during vacation periods. In fact, I met most of the children in this book during summer and winter breaks.

Their street vending schedule was fluid and ever changing, but one thing was for sure: summer was a very busy time. Most children in

36 | “IF I DON’T HELP THEM, WHO WILL?”

Time	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday
5:00 AM							
6:00					School		
7:00	School						
8:00						Sell with mom	
9:00							
10:00							
11:00							
12:00							
1:00 PM							
2:00							
3:00							
4:00							
5:00							
6:00							
7:00	help @				Sell @		
8:00	home.				park		
9:00							
10:00							
11:00							
12:00							
Income	\$	\$	\$	\$	\$ 120	\$ 200	\$ 200
From sales							

Total hours at work:

Figure 1.4. Handwritten work schedule of Josefina (age seventeen).

the Los Angeles Unified School District are out of school during the summer. Budget cuts have greatly affected summer classes available to students in the Los Angeles area.¹³ Lack of summer classes means that more children are now idle at home, often watching television or playing in the street with their friends. This is seldom the case with child street vendors, though. In fact, summer is the busiest time of the year for the children and youth who work with their parents as street vendors. The summer days, with temperatures reaching the high nineties, are the best season to sell raspados, cut-up fruit, aguas frescas (fruit-flavored water), elotes (corn on the cob), and tejuino. Since they do not have school responsibilities, they are able to street vend during the day and stay late at night without having to worry about assignments due the next day or getting up early to go to class.

Weekends Only

Other children worked only during the weekend, but their weekdays were packed with household and childcare work. Take the case of

Josefina as an example. My interview with Josefina started at sunset on the front porch of their small apartment, at around 6:00 p.m. Since she is the oldest, she is often left in charge of her little siblings. This was the case when I met her for our interview. Shortly after I arrived at Josefina’s house, her mom and stepfather drove out to do the laundry and she was left in charge of her fourteen-year-old sister Elsa, her five-year-old brother José, and her four-year-old brother Juan. During our three-hour interview, I was able to see how much work and responsibilities Josefina had on her plate. She makes sure her siblings eat, do their homework, and take a shower before they go to sleep. She also does behavior management. For example, her little brothers José and Juan interrupted the interview with a constant opening and slamming of the heavy iron front door. After a while, this banging noise became part of the background soundtrack that included cars passing by, children playing, neighbors blasting loud music, dogs barking, and a TV playing in the living room. The kids wanted attention from their sister and from me. Josefina constantly scolded them to stop, but my presence inspired extra curiosity that kept them peeking out the door.

An hour into the interview, we decided to move to the kitchen table, where there was light, because I had started using my phone light to read my interview questions. We passed through the living room, which was converted into a second bedroom with a queen-size bed, an armoire, and a large plasma television. Josefina’s younger sister and brothers lay on the bed watching *iCarly*, a TV show on the Nickelodeon channel. A curtain divided the kitchen from the improvised bedroom. Once in the kitchen, I sat on a chair by a small round table topped with a variety of food, including pan dulce (Mexican sweet bread), fruit, a box of small bags of chips, homemade salsa, and chiles curtidos (pickled jalapeños).

As in most of the houses I visited, the street vending merchandise was visible and stored around various living spaces. Josefina pointed at the few boxes of sodas and Gatorade bottles stacked next to the table and underneath it to explain what they sold on the weekend. In addition, she explained that she and her mother also sell hot dogs at a neighborhood park where large crowds join for friendly soccer games in the afternoon.

As we continued with our interview, Josefina’s five-year-old brother approached her for help with his kindergarten homework. We stopped the interview several times to help him with his homework. This

38 | “IF I DON’T HELP THEM, WHO WILL?”

involved reading the instructions, correcting what he had already done, and looking for crayons to complete the assignment. After the interview, I went to the street where her parents were street vending until midnight. Josefina still had to give her brothers and herself a bath, put them to bed, and finish her own school assignments.

Josefina’s street vending responsibilities have changed over time. She used to work more during the summer, but lately it has been more beneficial for her to stay home and care for her little siblings. She explained,

Well, I used to go more often during the summer. But now I have to stay home, so sometimes my mom goes by herself, but I mean, I have to do my homework. . . . [Also] I don’t want my brothers bugging my mom. So I keep them here at the house. . . . I keep my sister and my brothers here and I make sure they take a shower. I also put them to sleep because they don’t like sleeping early, but I make sure they go to sleep, and sometimes I clean the house.

In addition, Josefina is on top of her academic work and tries to protect her study time as best as family and street vending responsibilities permit. As a senior in high school, Josefina is busy preparing a graduation portfolio that includes a personal statement, a résumé, sample essays from previous classes, and more. Josefina gets as much work done as she can while she is at school and in her after-school program, but when she gets home, it is time to help her mother with the household responsibilities while her mother goes to street vend. Josefina explained,

Mostly the days that I would go help my mom is just Fridays, Saturdays, and Sundays. If we go on Fridays, which is rare, but I’ll go because I don’t have school on Saturday. But I’ll go help her Fridays in the afternoon. Then Saturdays I help her the whole morning until, let’s say, like five in the afternoon. And Sundays the same thing, like 5:00 a.m. to 5:30 p.m.

The children I interviewed had various work arrangements with parents. In addition to the type of street vending business, age, gender, and family composition helped determine when kids worked and how they helped. Others such as Josefina also worked during the week, but did so at home. Josefina seldom helped her mother with the street vending

business during the week because her mother’s business required no preparation at home. Her mother sold chips, Gatorade, juices, candy, and hot dogs at night. Since Josefina had younger siblings, it made more sense for her to stay home and watch over them. In contrast, Leticia, who did not have younger siblings, worked during the week on the street, preparing food, charging customers, arranging the merchandise, and running errands for her mother.

School Nights and Weekends

In addition to helping over the weekend, other children also helped during the week after school. The story of Mercedes and her two daughters, Adriana (age sixteen) and Norma (age fourteen) comes to mind. Mercedes is a single mother and to support her two daughters sells tamales early in the morning before her daughters go to school. She also sells chips, sodas, and an assortment of candy outside Norma’s school immediately after classes let out.

Mercedes’s workday starts very early. She sells tamales at four o’clock in the morning outside a factory in downtown Los Angeles while her two daughters are still sleeping. One early morning, I accompanied Mercedes as she prepared for and then went to work. I met her at her house at dawn; it was dark but the streetlights allowed me to see her loading into her small car a thermos with champurrado. She also loaded a jug of freshly squeezed orange juice, a small folding table, and an ice chest full of about sixty tamales. When I asked Mercedes whether her daughters helped, she explained that every night they gather around the kitchen table to *embarrar la masa* (spread the corn-based dough before adding the filling). Mercedes and her daughters form an assembly line where the youngest daughter takes the corn leaves drenched in a bucket of water and places them on the table, while Mercedes and her oldest daughter spread the masa, add the meat and mole (sauce), and fold the tamales inside a large pot. Time flies by quickly since they have a small television in their kitchen where they watch their favorite *novela* (soap opera).

I decided to follow Mercedes in my own car since her small car could not fit all of her merchandise plus an extra passenger. Mercedes parked on the street immediately in front of the small side entrance of the sewing factory, and then she instructed me to park behind her. She

40 | “IF I DON’T HELP THEM, WHO WILL?”

strategically used her car and my car as a shield to hide from the authorities. She placed her small folding table as close to the car as she could in order to not block the sidewalk. On the light post she placed a small 13" x 10" cardboard sign with the word “tamales” advertising her food. Mercedes diligently sold to new and regular customers. She usually makes about sixty to a hundred tamales per day. On that morning, since she did not sell all of the tamales she and her daughters had prepared the night before, she moved to a different spot at 6:30 a.m. after the factory closed the door. I helped her move down the street directly in front of a bus stop. Mercedes planned to get customers who were exiting the bus. She finally finished selling all of the tamales by 7:00 a.m., just in time to move her car because street parking is enforced at that time. After we loaded the car with the empty wares, an empty crate, and the table, Mercedes headed home at 7:15 to then drive her two daughters to their different schools. By this time, both of her daughters were up and ready for school. As soon as Mercedes parked in front of their apartment, the girls ran out, helped take the table and the empty containers out of the car, and went to school.

Meanwhile, I began my interview with her sister and next-door neighbor Carolina. When Mercedes returned around 9:00 a.m., she looked exhausted, so she took a nap. Mercedes slept during my two-hour interview with Carolina. After my interview, Mercedes got up and started getting ready to go street vend outside her daughter’s middle school, where her youngest daughter will help. I met Mercedes and Carolina at the middle school at 2:00 p.m. after I also took a nap inside my car parked in the parking lot of a fast-food restaurant near their house. When I arrived, they were setting up their merchandise. I offered to help arrange the candy since she was busy with the first wave of hungry kids leaving the school. Mercedes thanked me for offering, but said that her daughter would help her. “I always try to leave some work for my daughter,” she explained. When her daughter came out of school, she placed her backpack behind the stand and started hanging candy on a string with clothespins.

Mercedes’s actions were significant to me because her decision to include her daughter in her sales represented more than needing her help. Mercedes left work for her daughter on purpose to teach her how to

“IF I DON’T HELP THEM, WHO WILL?” | 41

earn money. Instilling a work ethic in her daughters was one of the main reasons for getting them involved in the family business.

The Work Kids Do

This chapter illuminates the experiences of street vending children and their parents who experience multiple disadvantages. Children such as Joaquín, Norma, and Salvador reveal how their decisions to street vend were constrained by their parents’ limited employment opportunities. Over and over, children cited their parents’ job misfortunes as the catalyst to street vending. While lack of formal education, poor English language skills, and lack of legal residency status placed their parents at a structural disadvantage, the children in this study and their families found in these structural constraints an opportunity for self-employment through a collective family work effort.

The children highlight their agency and decision making when it comes to deciding to street vend and help their family make ends meet. Children are not thrilled that they have to work. Who can blame them? After all, street vending is hard work. However, most children showed a high level of maturity when explaining how they decided to help their parents. Through my conversations with these young entrepreneurs, they revealed that their motives extended beyond familial obligations. Their decision to street vend was also a solution to obtain expensive consumer items their parents alone could not afford. For example, wanting to replace a lost iPod, as in the case of Karen, is not a matter of simply asking for a new one; rather, children realize that they must literally work to get a new one. In the process of their work, children learned to see their work as unique and different from other children at their schools and in their neighborhoods. Instead of seeing their work as cultural baggage, they created a higher morality that sees them as strong, hardworking, good sons and daughters, and not lazy, delinquent, and a burden for their parents.

Street vending as a family enterprise is more than a cultural legacy from México (and more generally Latin America) that is induced by structural labor market constraints encountered by Latinx immigrants who face racial discrimination and are denied legal authorization to

work in the United States. Street vending is an innovative form of self-employment, one that has created a market out of growing concentrations of co-ethnics, and now foodie tourists. We cannot explain the work of children in family business street vending as “either/or,” that is, as due exclusively to cultural factors or exclusively to structural factors. The line between culture and structure is not always so neat and definitive. For example, family household economies and the resources of poverty are structurally induced. In the United States, and in immigrant barrios such as East Los Angeles, hundreds of thousands of Mexican immigrant families—many of them without access to legal authorization to work—have migrated and settled. Faced with saturated labor markets and poor job options, many of them have chosen to devise incomes of ingenuity, responding to the structural constraints they encounter in East Los Angeles with cultural resources and practices that are common in their country of origin. Street vending is a cultural and economic resource with which they were familiar, and which they employ to counter structural limitations they face in U.S. labor markets.

In the next chapter, we will see how structural and cultural factors are intertwined in history and place settings. The cultural factors that are important in explaining the popularization of street vending in East Los Angeles include the tradition of working-class communities buying and eating traditional prepared foods on the streets and around the plazas in México and other Latin American countries and the systematic exclusion of Latinx immigrants from jobs that offer a living wage.

4

Making a Living Together

Communal Family Obligation Code and Economic Empathy

I Work Too MUCH To Be 17,
 I Sleep Little && Dnt Get Tireed Caause I'm YOUNG,
 I Have Never Had A Normal Teenage Life,
 Buut I Guess That's Whaat Maakes My Life So Unique, &&
 So Full Of Adventuress
 Sad/Mad/Happy/Unforgettable Memories That Shall Last
 Forever{:
 There's Always Time For The TeenageDream♥
 —Leticia, January 2012

Leticia had taken on many new responsibilities months before she posted this poem on her social media page, three years after I interviewed her for the first time, when she was only fourteen years old. On December 28, 2011, her mother, Nilda, suffered a stroke and was hospitalized for three months. I visited Nilda frequently in the hospital, and on numerous occasions I saw Leticia stop by after school and then go to La Cumbrita to street vend. Leticia had decided to continue street vending without her mother because she was the only one able to bring money into the household. In order to manage their street vending business, Leticia enlisted the help of two high school friends and other street vendors at La Cumbrita. Leticia's American generational resources were pivotal during this time, as she used her smartphone and Facebook page to communicate with their customers to inform them that they were still making and selling their famous quesadillas, fried tacos, and more.¹ She also used her Facebook to keep her friends and family informed of her mother's health. Leticia coordinated hospital visits with her mother's friends and relatives to ensure that someone was always at Nilda's bedside while Leticia was at school or vending.

Although it was difficult for Leticia to leave her mother alone in the hospital, she needed to keep vending in order for their family to avoid eviction from their home.

One evening, we sat together in Nilda's dark hospital room. Nilda lay prone on the bed with her eyes closed, and Leticia stared at her mother with tired eyes. Leticia had woken at six o'clock that morning, prepared the sauces for their business, attended school, then went to La Cumbrita to street vend. She was exhausted. "Es el pinche estress," said Leticia while she tenderly caressed her mother's hand, trying to avoid touching the heart monitor clipped onto her index finger letting us know she was still alive. "It's the fucking stress," she murmured again and again, switching from Spanish to English. Leticia blamed the stress they endured street vending for her mother's stroke. She told me countless stories of them getting citations while street vending. This made it difficult for them to stay afloat financially. On that night, I could see that the stress was getting to Leticia as well. She looked tired and overwhelmed, but she never lost faith that her mother would open her eyes again, and she did. Nilda was released from the hospital in March, three weeks before her birthday. Leticia felt that she had no choice but to continue the arduous schedule of waking up early, cooking, going to school, and then going to La Cumbrita to sell food. In fact, Leticia's street vending kept the family economically afloat for six months after her mother was released from the hospital. "I wouldn't let my mom do anything," said Leticia. "But I went to sell one day and she showed up and said she wasn't leaving because that was her *puesto*."²

The multiple intersections of oppression that push first-generation immigrants to work as street vendors also spill over to their U.S.-born children like Leticia. As an economic family strategy, the children of street vendors learn to labor side by side with their immigrant parents. As we saw with Leticia, sometimes the children of street vendors take on additional obligations in the household and in their street vending business when parents cannot work. Why?

The children of immigrants develop a special connection to their immigrant parents because they understand the sacrifices their parents make by immigrating to the United States and the social and economic marginalization they experience as immigrants. As sociologist Jody Agius Vallejo argues, the second generation retains strong social and financial obligations to their families and adopts an *immigrant narrative*

that is born out of their parents' migration experience, economic marginalization, and a shared struggle for mobility and belonging to explain why they give back socially and financially to their immigrant parents. Vallejo captured this immigrant narrative among the Latinx middle class. Vallejo also finds that the children of immigrants who grow up poor are more likely to give back financially to family or extended kin and are also more likely to provide social support than those raised in more economically stable households.³ Giving back can affect the mobility and economic security of the second generation because they are financially stretched due to the high financial demands that come from poor family and extended kin. The compulsion to help kin is a pattern that has been observed among African Americans as well.⁴

This chapter builds on Vallejo's work with the Mexican middle class by shedding light on how and why children adopt an ideology beyond an immigrant narrative. The child street vendors in this study are experiencing firsthand this form of immigrant sacrifice faced by immigrants in lower-sector occupations. The children in this study are not just adopting an immigrant narrative from their parents' harsh working conditions, but they develop a *communal family obligation code*, which holds that U.S.-born children must work with immigrant parents in myriad ways to make ends meet.⁵ This code differs drastically from the typical expectations of children in American society. Child street vendors in this study experience compounded disadvantages stemming from their parents' social locations rooted in unauthorized status, informal work, and stigma from their work. Yet street vending also sets the stage for children to develop *economic empathy*, resulting from experiencing their parents' position of oppression and their family's economic marginalization. Economic empathy is a behavior toward immigrant parents that is born out of the experience of working together to sustain the household and derives from a *shared struggle* that exposes the children of immigrants to their undocumented parents' labor struggles. In other words, economic empathy is fostered by the practice of communal family obligation to work together.

Communal Family Obligation and Remuneration

Day in and day out, child street vendors work with their parents, and many become integral to the functioning of the family business and the

family's economic stability. Child street vendors know firsthand the hard work that is required to make a living. They wake up early. They prepare food. They set up the tables. They handle money.⁶ They negotiate with clients. They devise marketing strategies to increase business. The children and the parents who work together have developed a communal family obligation code by which both parents and children benefit from making a living together. In this parent-child economic productive unit, kids must work, but they also reap economic benefits. The communal family obligation code is born out of necessity and derives from structural constraints and in turn creates stronger bonds and obligations among children and their parents. Children understand that their family's very economic survival depends on their contributions as well. Their relationship to money—how money is earned, distributed in the family, and spent—is central to street vending families because children are vital to this decision-making process.

The communal family obligation code is expressed in several different ways. The first way is that children do not expect to be paid for work. Among all my participants, the typical expectation that one should be paid for a day's work was rejected in favor of helping the family. The idea of receiving payment for work was almost insulting to children. For example, when I asked fourteen-year-old Susana whether her parents ever paid her for her help, she immediately said no. She explained it this way: "No, I'm not that kind of person, 'cause I don't ask them, like, 'Oh, I helped you, so are you gonna pay me or something?'" However, this does not mean that children never feel that their parents owe them some form of compensation. Susana clarified, "If we work here on Fridays, we'll go to the mall the next day, and I'll be like, 'Okay, can you buy me this?'" With confidence, Susana added, "I think I earn what they buy me." Children knew that if they worked with their parent, they had earned the right to ask for things.

Rather than getting paid an hourly wage for their work, they engage in *family bartering*, or rules of exchange and remuneration between parents and children. When children sell merchandise by themselves, they typically hand all of the day's earnings off to their mother, father, or even an older sibling. Fewer than half of the interviewees said they receive cash regularly from their parents as compensation for vending. And when they did, the amount for a day's work varied between five

and thirty dollars, a small sum compared to a typical day's take. With this cash, they buy everyday necessities, items such as shoes and school supplies, but also some nice extras that children and teens desire in a consumer-driven society, such as video games and brand-name jeans. The majority of the kids, however, do not ask their parents for money. Rather, they barter for specific items. In her book *Consuming Citizenship*, sociologist Lisa Sun-Hee Park studied the children of Korean and Chinese immigrant entrepreneurs in thirty-six different types of businesses and found that most kids do not get paid and very few get twenty dollars a day for their help.⁷ In contrast to the children of street vendors, some of the kids in Park's study who did not get paid did not want to receive payment because they did not want their parents to feel more entitled to boss them around.

On the other hand, child street vendors have expressed feelings of appreciation toward their parents and do not demand payment because they feel that the food, clothes, and education that they get from their parents are payment enough. In some cases, the children in my study feel empowered and know that they can get anything they want because they help their parents. Alejandro explained, "I don't really ask her for money because . . . I'd rather ask her for things like shoes." Similarly, when I asked Leticia whether she got paid for keeping the family afloat during her mother's illness, she paused for a second, tilted her head, looked up, and after a short "ummmm" sound, she explained,

Like, for example, I can work all these days and I can tell my mom, "Can I go to the movies?" And she will give me, like, ten dollars to buy the movie ticket or buy some food or to go out with my friends. Or she will give me money to buy shoes or something like that. Oh yeah! She also pays my cell phone bill.

These children received from their parents what most middle-class children receive without having to work.⁸ Rather than feeling entitled to these privileges—money for social outings with friends, clothes, food, and payment of their cell phone bill—they felt that they had to earn them. As thirteen-year-old Nadya explained, "If I want some new clothes, I have to earn it, like I have to work. I have to help my mom. . . . Whatever we want my mom buys it for us, like the *comida* [food], all the

clothes, the shoes, so, like, that's how it works." Gloria added, "My mom buys more for my older sister because she works more with them. My other sisters, the one who is fourteen, does not get a lot of things because she only stays home and takes care of my brothers and sisters." Early on, children understand that the work done outside the home is valued and rewarded more. Tasks like cleaning and taking care of siblings are not valued or compensated as much, an issue that I will discuss in the following chapter. Children recognized their communal family obligation code as a matter of fact. Their street vending work helps parents, but it also helps them. To put it in Alejandro's words,

It's help, because sometimes she gives me money and sometimes she doesn't. It's not that I want the money. I just do it for the help, because I know she is the one that needs the money the most. Well, we both do because we live under the same roof, so most if not all the money goes to our house, our rent and to stuff that we need.

Economic incentives blended together with children's moral obligations to help support their families. This communal family obligation code is developed early in their childhood. Parents recognize that like most children, their own children crave the latest technology and material goods, but they also have limited resources to buy their kids what they desire. In addition, they cannot afford to hire help, and so children's labor becomes integral to their ability to support the family unit. Parents like Lorena recognized that the only way to give their children what they wanted was if the children contributed their labor. Lorena elaborated,

Yes, they do help. For example, I have to cut fruit, make the jam and prepare the dough. Then imagine if I had to pay someone else. Then, it is not that I am saving money. I tell my son, "Here is five dollars" or whatever. On Monday, he bought an iPod. He had to sacrifice a lot to save up and buy his iPod. Look, they want their little luxuries. Then, it is help for us and for them, too.⁹

Almadelia also believes it is better to obtain help from her children instead of hiring anyone else. "Si alguien tiene que contratar alguna

persona, es mejor que se venga el hijo. Se ayudan.” (If someone has to hire a person, it is better for it to be your child. It’s mutual help.) Similarly, when I asked Nilda, Leticia’s mom, whether she paid her kids for helping, she replied with a firm “No” and then burst into laughter and added, “Pero me saca lo que quiere.” (She gets whatever she wants out of me.) Nilda elaborated,

I don’t pay my little girl, but she gets whatever she wants out of me. I tell her, if you help me I will pay for your cell phone, if you help me I will buy you pants, if you help me I will buy you this.¹⁰

The communal family obligation code leads to intimate knowledge of family needs typically associated with adult responsibilities. Parents and children learn that they must work together in order to fulfill these family needs as well as their personal desires for material goods. In our current consumer age, sociologist Allison Pugh reminds us, childhoods have become more commercialized, and children in the United States want too many material things.¹¹ According to Park, consumerism is key for Asian American children and their parents to demonstrate their U.S. citizenship.¹² Furthermore, for the children and the parents in Park’s study, the participation of children in the family business was a stepping stone to getting an education. Most of the parents pressured their children to go to prestigious universities and study majors that would lead to profitable careers. Ensuring that their children had prosperous futures guaranteed parents a retirement. In addition, a high-paying career would allow their children to buy cars, houses, and clothes that would show their success in this country to fellow Asian immigrants and to White Americans.

A major difference between the children of Asian entrepreneurs and child street vendors is the context of their work. The Asian entrepreneurs were small business owners; the Latinx street vending children work with their parents in the informal sector of the economy. According to Park, the Asian entrepreneurs were seen as hardworking and model minorities, while the Latinx kids and their parents are criminalized on a regular basis for the work that they do in very public and visible spaces.¹³ Despite the different nature of the job, both Asian and Latinx kids expressed pride in their parents’ work and said that they

were happy that their parents worked for themselves. Notably, none of the children who shared their story with me desired to have a “White boss.”

Economic Empathy

Compared to children who do not work with their parents, working children are more mindful of how they spent the money they received from selling on the street. The children who worked with their parents developed an empathetic stance toward their parents that I call economic empathy, a resiliency that results from experiencing their parents’ position of oppression. Economic empathy develops not just from working together but from working tirelessly to help support the family. Scholars refer to the work that children do for their parents based on obligation or deep feelings of guilt, love, and concern as the labor of love.¹⁴ Children often make sacrifices to work in order to help their parents or their younger siblings. This is often the case with farmworkers and their families.¹⁵ In her book *Voices from the Fields: Children and Migrant Farmworkers Tell Their Stories*, S. Beth Atkin assembles a collection of autobiographical stories of young children who work with their parents doing farm work in California. In these essays, the children describe their everyday lives, which include going to school and sometimes missing school in order to help with the farm work. Atkin writes, “One of the most disturbing yet also heartening situations I encountered were older siblings who chose to drop out of school to work in the fields so a younger sister or brother could finish school and improve her or his life.”¹⁶ Atkin captures the sacrifices that individual family members make for the good of the entire family.

Additionally, most children who worked with their parents as street vendors feel that it is their responsibility to help relieve some of their parents’ economic burden. For example, fourteen-year-old Amanda earns five dollars every time she works with her mother, and she saves her hard-earned money in a box inside her clothing drawer in case her mother ever needs money. She confessed to wanting to use her money for toys, but, because she has worked in the business and understands that their income from street vending fluctuates, she knows that there are days when one can come up short of cash or that unforeseen economic

emergencies are frequent. At a young age, she realized that helping her mother was more important than indulging in material things like toys. Rather than buying things for herself, she frequently loans her mother money to buy fruit for the business. This type of labor of love is relatively unusual in most contemporary Western societies.

In addition, street vending children *experience* their parents' pain, which is also their own. Children feel a strong empathy with their parents and often frame their work as a responsibility. Leticia told me, "I don't really see this like a job. I see it more like our responsibility. Like, I have to be there to help my mom, so she won't get that tired." Similar to Leticia, seventeen-year-old Clara choked back tears as she said, "We feel my mom's pain for working." Clara and her mother sell fresh cut-up fruit. Many times, she has helped her mother hide their wares and fruit behind parked cars in the parking lot during police raids. These moments help Clara value her mom's work and the risks involved. These experiences transcend an immigrant narrative and are the substance of daily dialogues, even something that parents talk about with their children after work or over dinner conversations.

Parents also describe having closer relationships with the children who worked with them. The parents emphasize that economic empathy results from working together and sharing the common struggle of running from the cops and selling in all kinds of weather. For example, despite having two older brothers, Leticia is the only one who helps her mother street vend. One son is Leticia's twin and the other is eighteen years old. During my interview with Nilda, she distinguished between the relationships she had with her kids. Nilda confessed that she was more attached to Leticia and attributed this attachment to gender, but she also emphasized the fact that they worked together. Nilda said that her relationship with her children, especially her daughter, would be different if she worked in the formal sector, like at a factory or a restaurant, because they would not witness her struggle.

My daughter is living what I am doing. She knows, for example, Leticia knows that I get tickets [citations], about the police, [having to work in] the rain, the water, everything. All of my kids also know about this, but they don't live it. . . . My relationship with Leticia is more of attachment [*apegamiento*]. What happens is that she is a girl and I have more trust

[*confianza*] in her for everything. And with my sons, we talk less. They are less attached to me. Why? For the same reasons . . . They don't interact [*conviven*] with me.

Nilda reiterates her realization that both interaction and spending time together at work help create not only empathy, but economic empathy. Héctor's words help to better clarify this concept:

When our children realize how we earn our money, it is difficult for them to take the wrong path. Because they say, "My dad or my mom work hard to earn money and how could I waste it."

Parents were confident that if children experienced firsthand the conditions under which money is earned through street vending, children would have a stronger appreciation and respect for parents and the money they earned. Parents also believe that working together buffers children from joining gangs or doing drugs, or what they described as "taking the wrong path." This sentiment is echoed by the children. Seventeen-year-old Clara told me that her relationship with her mother was special. She told me that she does not ask her mother for many things because she knows how much work it takes to earn a dollar. She compares her life with the lives of friends who splurge on consumer items carelessly. She believes that if her friends worked as much as she did, they would not be as demanding with their parents. Clara told me,

I would like people to come here and see that it is not easy. We see my mom suffer. I see friends that don't do anything. They go shopping and I tell them, "Dude, while you're shopping I'm working my ass off over here." A lot of people make fun of my mom or me, but if they only knew. Then they would be saying, "Don't buy me this, don't buy me that." I think my relationship with my mother is special.

Clara's quote encapsulates the meaning of economic empathy. Clara explains how she sees her mom suffer and she connects that to her own pain as well. She states that many people make fun of her mom and they also make fun of her for street vending. She recognizes that she works hard just like her mom does. She then shows us what economic empathy

is not. In comparing herself to her friend, she implies that if they had economic empathy toward their parents, they would not ask for excessive material goods. Clara ends by saying that the relationship with her mother is special. Their shared struggle creates economic empathy and brings them closer.

Rejection of Parental Work

Economic empathy and a communal family obligation code develop only among the children who work with their parents and who had first-hand experience of the difficulty of earning a living doing street vending work. I also interviewed families in which children do not work alongside their parents, and they espoused ideologies about work and family that were very different from those of their working peers. Street vending youth also spoke extensively about their siblings, cousins, or friends who did not street vend. Paradoxically, the children who develop a sense of communal family obligation and economic empathy see themselves in sharp contrast to their nonworking peers, whom they view as lazy and irresponsible, and as bad sons and daughters. Fourteen-year-old Linda compared herself with her cousin of the same age who did not help. Linda's aunt sells tamales. Linda describes the difference:

I learn to understand my mom. When one of my aunts started losing days at work, like, my cousin wouldn't understand. She would want to do the same things when her mom couldn't afford it anymore. So it's like, I learn to understand that when my mom has money, I feel comfortable asking my mom, "Can you buy me this?" But when I know, like, the sales didn't go good, I won't ask [my mom] for money.

Linda's economic empathy helped her know when bartering with her mom was appropriate and when it was not. Linda's cousin, on the other hand, lacked economic empathy and as Linda points out, her cousin did not understand that her mother could not afford the things she used to buy when she was working more hours at her employment. Linda makes it very clear that she "learned to understand" when not to ask.

Sixteen-year-old Josefina also had a cousin, Angela, who did not work with her street vending parents. Josefina expressed frustration over her

cousin's lack of support and economic empathy toward her parents. She explained, "My cousin takes everything for granted." Unlike Josefina, Angela frequently asked for money even if she knew sales were slow. Josefina expressed economic empathy when she added, "My aunt would bust her butt and everything and my cousin just doesn't care." Josefina contrasted her experience with that of her cousin this way:

I try to look for things I like and I ask myself, "Do I really need them?" . . . I look for specials and everything and my cousin . . . just, like, makes her mom make food every night. Like [my aunt] barely gets sleep and [my cousin] doesn't care. It came to a point where my aunt hired me to come help her every night. And, you know, having a daughter. We are the same age. I'm four months older than her.

Josefina's body language could not hide the frustration she felt toward her cousin. She would tighten her fist, shake her head, roll her eyes, and even extend her arms to demonstrate her lack of understanding when she said, "And, you know, having a daughter." Josefina found it perplexing that a daughter would not help her own mother. Her own gendered expectations were not met, and that was frustrating for her. Here it is important to remember Nilda's words, "All of my kids also know about this, but they don't live it." Economic empathy is the result of practice and a shared work struggle, one that Josefina's cousin simply did not have.

Intrigued by Josefina's description of her cousin, I interviewed Angela as part of my comparison group of children who do not work with their street vending parents. Most interviews with street vending children took from one to three hours, but my interview with Angela was only fifteen minutes long. She had very little interest in her mother's street vending business and mostly shrugged her shoulders, followed by an "I don't know" to questions pertaining to the business. Similar to other children who did not street vend with their parents, Angela told me that her mother had made the fateful decision to street vend. Angela also spent a lot of her free time with her father, who had remarried and lived in Pasadena, a town a few miles away from Boyle Heights, where her mother lives. Being removed from her mother's daily struggle prevented Angela from developing economic empathy, a sharp contrast to Josefina, her cousin.

The lack of economic empathy among children who do not street vend with their parents did not mean that the nonworking children do not love and appreciate their parents. However, the youth in this group were removed from their parents' street vending struggles, and some even expressed feelings of embarrassment about their parents' work.¹⁷ For example, fourteen-year-old Glenda relayed, "I hate it when she sells tamales outside my school." Children who did not work with their parents ignored the social structures that pushed their parents to street vend. They also missed out on the opportunity to develop an economic stance that would have proved useful in countering stigma associated with street vending. Nonworking children did not understand how difficult it was to find employment and the sacrifices required to earn money street vending. These children often developed a level of resentment toward their parents for "choosing" to work as street vendors. Some could not understand why their parents could not get a "normal" job instead.

Fourteen-year-old Betty is an example of this pattern. Betty did not work with her mother and she was embarrassed that her mother was a street vendor. She wanted her mother to get a "normal" job cleaning houses, working as a janitor, or distributing newspapers. Betty perceived these service sector jobs as higher in status than street vending. When I interviewed Betty in the kitchen of her family's small two-bedroom apartment, she was eating a cup of instant noodles. Her mother had left tamales that morning for both of us to eat. As I ate two tamales, Betty made a face of disgust and said she was tired of tamales and preferred to eat noodles. I could not relate to Betty; in my own house, we eat tamales only during Christmas, so eating tamales in July was a treat! Later in the interview, I asked Betty whether she had saved money from her allowance. She responded with a cutting "No."

During our interview, furthermore, I asked, "Why don't you save money?" "Usually I just spend it all. I just don't save it," replied Betty. Unlike the youth who worked with their parents, Betty was very detached from her mother's work and even came to view the tamales that her mother sells as emblematic of an abnormal occupation. When I asked her what she liked about her mother's work, she replied in a high voice, "Nothing. Nothing. I'm tired of it. It's her decision to sell them [tamales] because we need money." Betty failed to recognize that her mother's undocumented status pushed her to the underground economy. Betty

was certain that, like her father who worked as a newspaper distributor, her mother could also find another type of work.¹⁸ Rather than feeling empathy toward her mother, though, she expressed frustration and saw it as her mother's decision to do this type of work.

Just because children who work with their parents have developed a sense of economic empathy does not mean that they do not experience tensions with their parents. The chief complaint relayed by working children is that they work too much. This is a common complaint among children of Asian entrepreneurs as well. For example, in her study on Chinese families in Britain, Miri Song stated, "All of the young people interviewed in this study stressed that the shop ran their lives."¹⁹ Similarly, the street vending children I spoke with saw their work as stealing their childhood and golden teenage years that should be spent hanging out with friends, going to theme parks, and extracurricular activities. You might recall Leticia's poem in the opening of this chapter, when she states, "I Work Too MUCH To Be 17," followed by "I Have Never Had A Normal Teenage Life." Although children rationalized their work as a family obligation, they did feel overworked at times. Patricia, who is just one year younger than Leticia, reflected,

I think there is a limit, because, you know, we are young and we wanna, like, have fun. Have our *juventud* [youth], you get me? But, I mean, it's good that we help. It's just—there should be a limit.

Other children also complained about not having time to go out with friends because they had to work. For example, Josefina, who is also sixteen, complained about not being able to go out with her friends to the movies or to Disneyland. These social outings with her friends often clashed with the time she worked on the weekend. During our interview, she confided,

Sometimes it sucks because, I mean, I do give up a lot of things. Like, there are times that my friends are like, "Oh, let's go to the movies," and I'll be like, "No." . . . We finish [street vending] at five, so, like, after six I could go. My mom would give me permission, but they always want to go early. Last week they invited me to Disneyland but I'm like, "No, I can't go because I have to help my mom." My sister wasn't here to help her and

then my stepdad goes to work somewhere else, so I'm like, "How is she gonna work with two kids?" and then I'm all like, "No." But I have given up stuff, but, I mean, I guess I have to.

Josefina was very mature and felt responsible for helping her mother. She did not see herself going to the movies or to Disneyland while her mother worked alone. These types of conflicts with her work and her social life created tensions between daughter and mother. Josefina was allowed to go out with friends after work, but after work hours was typically too late for her friends.

In contrast, nonworking children lacked economic empathy because they did not take part in the communal family obligation code with their parents and because they did not see their works as normal. Context makes a difference in how children and families make sense of their work and family obligations. Miri Song found that "expectations that children should help out emerged in a context where there was an awareness that other Chinese children in Britain also helped out in their takeaway businesses."²⁰ The Chinese children saw the take-away business as a normal job for immigrants. Some accepted this completely and believed that it was the best option for their parents since they did not speak English. They also saw that other families like them had similar businesses. Their work and their business seemed normal. In fact, not working was the exception. According to Song, some parents even used shame or guilt to get their children to help. These parents compared their children to model Chinese children who helped their parents.

The difference here is that the children I interviewed did not see street vending as a normal job for their parents. The informality of street vending made it difficult for families to openly talk about their business and it was seldom seen as a source of pride. In fact, parents and children constantly challenged negative stereotypes so that they could construct their work as dignified (see chapter 1). In addition, the children who worked with their parents did so in isolation from other children. This was evident in many ways. When I asked children to refer me to other street vending children, many of them could not think of people to recommend for my study. Also, when I asked them whether their school friends worked, many said that their friends did not work. One kid even said that her friends' parents worked for their children. In this context,

the economic empathy that results from a communal family obligation code serves as a buffer against these intergenerational tensions. The children who work with their parents as street vendors *conviven* (interact or spend quality time) with their parents. While the children of Korean and Chinese entrepreneurs can prove their “Americanness” through the consumer items that their work offers them,²¹ street vending provides the children in my study the exact opposite. Street vending helps confirm the “otherness.” Even though the majority of the child street vendors are U.S. citizens, some attended private schools, and most lived in homes owned by their parents, once on the streets, their immigrant shadow surfaced, and so did their economic empathy.